

Flash Builder 4.5 is Adobe's preferred development tool for building applications with the Flex 4.5 SDK. Flash Builder is available for both Windows and Mac OS X. Although you can develop and deploy Flex applications to the Web or the desktop with the free Flex SDK, Flash Builder is a worthwhile investment that can increase developer productivity, reduce bugs, speed up coding, and generally make the process of developing a Flex application much more enjoyable.

Flash Builder was named Flex Builder in releases prior to version 4. It's been renamed by Adobe to position it as the preferred programmer's editor for all Flash Player programming, whether by Flash or Flex developers. You can get Flash Builder from Adobe as a free limited-time trial, or you can purchase a license. Flash Builder can be installed either as a stand-alone installation that includes everything you need or as a plug-in on top of an existing installation of Eclipse. Regardless of which installation option you select, Flash Builder runs as a plug-in, or an integrated component, of another software product called Eclipse. So, before installing Flash Builder, it's important to understand the nature of Eclipse first. To install Flash Builder as a plug-in on top of your existing Eclipse installation, use the appropriate installation application for your operating system. The Flash Builder plug-in installation is self-explanatory. Just follow the prompts to complete the installation, and then start up your copy of Eclipse. Along the way, you'll be asked whether you want to install a full copy of Eclipse as a preview or install the plug-in into an existing Eclipse installation.

Using Flash Builder

Flash Builder has a common set of tools that you use to create and test Flex applications, whether it's installed with the stand-alone or plug-in configuration. In this section, we describe the most common tasks related to Flex application development: creating a Flex project and finding Help resources.

Creating a Flex project

An Eclipse project is a collection of applications and their associated resources. When using Flash Builder, you should create your project as a resource known as a Flex project. In addition to standard Eclipse project settings, a Flex project contains many configuration options that are designed specifically for Flex developers. Choose File > New > Flex Project from the Flash Builder menu to create a new Flex project.